Interview worksheet — research into agentic AI in SMEs (English)

Questionnaire v2.1 with addendum v2.2 (sales questions and conversation order) · English version for English-language interviews, identical in content to the Dutch worksheet · twelve main questions · 40 minutes maximum · MIT project 28436 · mark every note with **H** (current practice), **V** (expectation) or **O** (personal opinion) · code and enter within 48 hours via the entry form

Interview number	Date	Interviewer	Company + respondent/role (not entered, scheduling only)

0. Introduction and consent

minute 0–4

Read aloud: *"For our MIT research project we are studying how companies use AI and what needs and conditions they see for AI systems that can also carry out actions. We will talk about your use of AI, sales, marketing and broader business processes. The conversation takes 40 minutes at most. There are no right or wrong answers. Even if you do not use AI or do not know the term AI agent, your contribution is valuable. You can skip any question or end the conversation."* Explain how the data is processed.

☐ Participation agreed Recording: ☐ yes ☐ no ☐ not asked ☐ Notes agreed

Definitions (read aloud if needed): an AI agent can, within agreed boundaries, carry out several steps to complete a task, for example retrieving information and then performing an action in another system. Ordinary automation is not AI. Use the example card only if the term is unknown; note its use.

> **Tone: a good conversation, not an interrogation**
>
> It is a conversation with a storyline: from **knowledge** (what they can do), through **use and application** (sales, marketing, projects, the future), to **legislation** as the closing piece. The respondent first tells their full story before the rules come up, so the legal questions land on concrete examples of their own. Let their anecdotes carry the conversation; tick the boxes right after the interview, during it write only key words and quotes. Read the green bridge lines aloud as transitions. Share your own (legal) knowledge only after their answer, otherwise you steer the answer; at the end you may share generously as a thank-you.

Short company profile

Sector: ☐ Construction/installation ☐ Energy ☐ IT/software ☐ Business services ☐ Logistics/transport ☐ Manufacturing/industry ☐ Food ☐ Retail/wholesale ☐ Healthcare/education ☐ Other: _____

Employees: ☐ 1 (self-employed) ☐ 2–9 ☐ 10–49 ☐ 50–249 ☐ 250+ **Region:** ☐ Flevoland ☐ Amsterdam Metropolitan Area ☐ Elsewhere in the Netherlands

Block 1: AI knowledge and skills (AI literacy)

minute 4–8

> *"Let's simply start with today: what is AI already doing in your company, and how good have you become at using it?"*

K1. What does your company use AI for at the moment, and what does it actually deliver?

If no use: what is the main reason? Since when; which tools; note the literal gist (H).

Coding AI use: ☐ daily ☐ occasionally ☐ no, but interested ☐ no, no plans **Familiar with AI agents:** ☐ unknown ☐ somewhat ☐ well

K2. How does your company make sure employees understand what AI can and cannot do, and use it responsibly? And who decides on the use of AI?

Follow-up: is there training or learning, or does everyone teach themselves? Note the respondent's involvement in AI decisions.

Estimate of team AI literacy: ☐ low (incidental, no agreements) ☐ basic (a few skilled, nothing written down) ☐ advanced (training or agreements in place)

The legal side of literacy (K3) returns in the legislation block at the end; here note the practice only.

Block 2: AI in sales **minute 8–14**

> *"Now the most exciting part: sales, where the revenue comes from. That is exactly where it gets interesting what you would and would not entrust to an AI agent."*

S1. What role would AI be allowed to play in your sales process, from first customer contact to quotation, and where is the line for you?

Follow-up: what already happens with AI in sales today? Note the literal gist.

S2 (7a). Would you trust an AI agent to draw up a quotation on its own and send it straight to the customer, without anyone seeing it first?

☐ yes, fully autonomous ☐ only with prior approval ☐ no, never Why (literal gist): _____

S3 (7b). May an AI agent set prices or discounts on its own, within boundaries you define in advance?

☐ yes ☐ only within strict boundaries ☐ no, pricing stays human work Comments: _____

S4 (7c). May an AI agent follow up leads on its own, so approach or email potential customers itself?

☐ yes, fully autonomous ☐ only with prior approval ☐ no Comments: _____

Block 3: Marketing **minute 14–20**

> *"From selling to being visible: marketing. That is often where AI already does the most, and also where things go wrong fastest towards customers."*

5. Does your company currently use AI for marketing or customer communication, and if so: for what exactly?

Keep it short if K1 already covered this; only add the marketing part. Follow-up: one recent application and what it delivered or disappointed.

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6. Which marketing tasks would an AI agent be allowed to take over from your company, and which not?

Follow-up: which action fully autonomously, including publishing or sending, and for which action do you want to approve first?

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7. Suppose AI creates an advertisement, mailing or social media post for your company. What do you judge it on before it goes to customers?

Follow-up: who checks such AI content before publication? If no use: how would you want to organise that check?

Short notes sales and marketing (H/V/O)

Current application or reason for non-use: _____ · Desired task and boundaries: _____

Checking of AI output: _____ · Sales boundary (quotations/prices/leads): _____

Gap signal: _____ · Insufficient insight: ☐ yes ☐ no · Example card used: ☐ yes ☐ no

Time check: move on to project management by minute 20 at the latest.

Block 4: Project management **minute 20–27**

> *"Now into the engine room: how the work itself is organised, from order to delivery."*

1. How does your company organise the execution of projects, from order to delivery?

Follow-up: what takes the most time or goes wrong most often? Which software, automation or AI for planning and monitoring?

2. Which tasks in your projects would an AI agent be allowed to take over from you, and which tasks not?

Follow-up: what must it deliver concretely (time, money, fewer mistakes)? Does it happen already? No task at all is also an answer.

Coding tasks (allowed autonomously): ☐ planning ☐ cash flow ☐ quotations/reports ☐ customer communication ☐ content ☐ campaigns ☐ none at all

3. Which decisions in a project would an AI agent be allowed to take on its own, and which do you always want to keep taking yourself?

Follow-up: name one decision that will always need an employee's approval first. Why that one?

4. Suppose an AI agent plans something wrong in a project and it costs your company money. How would you notice the mistake, and how would you fix it?

Follow-up: how to monitor continuously, who steps in first? The question of who is responsible returns in the legislation block; remember this example and refer back to it there.

Coding oversight: ☐ approve everything in advance ☐ only important decisions in advance ☐ checking afterwards is enough ☐ fully autonomous is fine

Short notes project management (H/V/O)

Current way of working: _____ · Desired task and benefit: _____

Boundaries, oversight and fixing mistakes: _____ (responsibility for mistakes: see legislation block)

Gap signal: _____ · Insufficient insight: ☐ yes ☐ no · Example card used: ☐ yes ☐ no

Time check: move on to AI agents for SMEs by minute 27 at the latest.

Block 5: AI agents for SMEs **minute 27–32**

> *"Let's look ahead for a moment: suppose it were possible tomorrow, what would need to happen?"*

9. Which activities in your company take the most time, if we leave projects, sales and marketing aside for a moment?

Follow-up: could an AI agent help there? What makes this process suitable or unsuitable?

10. Suppose your company wanted to start with an AI agent tomorrow: what would you need, and what is still in the way right now?

Follow-up (only if the respondent does not raise it): knowledge in the team, costs, quality of your own data, integrations. Who would manage the agent day to day?

Coding biggest barrier: ☐ trust (visibility/correction) ☐ privacy/company data (GDPR) ☐ liability ☐ costs/returns ☐ knowledge ☐ other

11. Under which conditions would your company invest money in an AI agent?

Follow-up: which measurable improvement as a minimum? A hard reason not to invest? What do you expect from the supplier? Willingness to pay: which pricing model fits and what order of magnitude? "It depends" is a good answer; note what it depends on. Mark as V.

Coding amount per month: ☐ nothing ☐ up to €50 ☐ €50–150 ☐ €150–500 ☐ €500–1,500 ☐ >€1,500 ☐ it depends **Pricing model:** ☐ per month ☐ per user ☐ per project ☐ one-off ☐ it depends

12. What help from outside your company would enable you to start with AI agents?

Follow-up: advice, training, funding or subsidy, a network, a knowledge institution. From whom do you expect that support? Mention examples only if the respondent does not raise them.

Coding support: ☐ expert advice ☐ team training ☐ subsidy/funding ☐ examples ☐ knowledge institution ☐ no need

Short notes AI agents for SMEs (H/V/O)

Process and desired use: _____ · Barriers and needs: _____

Investment conditions and supplier: _____ · Pricing model and order of magnitude: _____

External support: _____ · Gap signal: _____ · Insufficient insight: ☐ yes ☐ no · Example card used: ☐ yes ☐ no

Block 6: Legislation — what exists, what is known, what is missing

minute 32–37

> *"You have now told me what you would and would not entrust to AI. To finish, the part I am extra curious about as a law student: the rules of the game. Not as a quiz, I am genuinely curious how this looks from the shop floor."*

8. If your company uses AI with customer data or in direct customer contact: what concerns do you have, and which rules do you take into account?

Two steps. Step 1, open: which laws or rules do you know here? (let them name these themselves first, note literally). Step 2, only if little comes up: mention the GDPR and the European AI Act and ask whether they are known and whether it is clear what they mean for this company.

Coding familiarity with rules: ☐ not familiar ☐ heard of, meaning unclear ☐ broadly familiar ☐ well familiar

Named spontaneously: _____ · Recognised only after prompting: _____

J1. Back to your earlier example: suppose an AI agent makes a mistake there that costs your company money. Who is responsible in your view: your company, the supplier of the agent, or someone else?

Mark as O; note "I don't know" literally, that is a finding in itself. Answer: _____

K3. Did you know that the European AI Act requires companies to ensure sufficient AI literacy among employees who work with AI?

Known: ☐ *yes* ☐ *no · Reaction (literal): _____*

V8-closing. Which rule or clarity do you feel is missing around AI in your company?

Note literally. Answer: _____

W1. If tomorrow you could ask the government for one rule or one piece of clarity around AI in your company: what would it be?

Note literally as O; feeds the gaps chapter. "I don't know" also counts. Answer: _____

Short notes legislation (H/V/O)

Concerns, rules and customer data: _____ · View on responsibility for mistakes (O): _____

Gap signal: _____ · Insufficient insight: ☐ yes ☐ no

Closing minute 37–40

Closing question: what do you see as the biggest opportunity of AI agents for a company like yours, and what is your biggest concern?

Follow-up: would more clarity from government or legislation take that concern away, and if so: which clarity exactly? Mark as O.

Biggest opportunity: _____ · Biggest concern: _____

Desired clarity from government/legislation: _____

Summarise the main points and have them confirmed; room for one important addition:

_____

Later contact: ☐ yes ☐ no Anonymised quoting: ☐ yes ☐ no

Receive whitepaper: ☐ yes ☐ no email: _____

Thank-you for the entrepreneur (after the closing question)

Give something back: share one or two insights from the desk research that match their answers, for example that the AI Act requires companies to ensure AI literacy among employees who work with AI, or how liability for AI mistakes is currently arranged. Tell them they will be the first to receive the whitepaper in December with what 15 to 20 fellow entrepreneurs answered, anonymised (the whitepaper is published in Dutch). That is the reward for their time.

Thank the respondent; stop by minute 40 at the latest. Afterwards: write up, code and enter within 48 hours via inclufy.com/ai-onderzoek?invoer=interview (see work instruction). No name or company name of the respondent in the entry. The entry form is in Dutch; the ticked coding boxes on this worksheet map one to one onto its fields. K1/K2/K3 feed the AI-use field plus the gap register; S1–S4 the sales-boundary note field; W1 the gap register.

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